Montgomery Bus Boycott

Rosa Parks is best known for the famous Montgomery Bus Boycott where she took a stand and fought against giving her seat to a white person. The prevailing laws and customs at that time dictated that bus passengers should be segregated on the basis of their race. The front seats of every bus were reserved for white people and the blacks were required to sit at the back. It was also thought to be a normal practice for black people to give their seat to white people when asked to do so.

On December 1, 1955, after a tiring work day, Parks boarded the Cleveland Avenue Bus. She paid her fare and sat in the ‘colored’ section of the bus at the rear, as the rules dictated at the time. Her seat was directly behind the seats reserved for whites and ironically the driver was the same person who had refused to allow Parks to enter the bus from the front in 1943.

The bus ran its normal route and the ‘white only’ seats in front of Parks began to fill up slowly. Eventually, many white passengers entered the bus and crowded it to the point where there was no room to sit and many were standing. The driver then asked the black passengers including Parks to give their seats to the white passengers who were standing. There were three other black people with Parks who gave their seat away but Parks refused to do so.

The driver threatened Parks and stated that he would call the police if she did not move from her seat but Parks remained resolute. She did not move and declared that the driver could call the police if he wished to do so. Her act of refusal became a fight for rights she deserved, which later became recorded in history. Parks was arrested by a police officer who told her that she was being arrested for breaking the law. Parks replied that she was being arrested because “white people like to push black people around”.

Parks was bailed out of jail the next day by Edgar Nixon who was the president of the Montgomery chapter of the NAACP. Her protest became popular among Americans and encouraged others to fight for their rights. There was a strong push to abandon sectional seating on the basis of race.